How to Answer Literature Set-Book Questions

A study method for any JAMB literature text

JAMB tests the recommended texts for the year. This guide gives you a method that works for any prose, drama or poetry text. It is not a summary of any book.

1. Build a one-page profile for each text

- **Title, author and genre** (prose, drama or poetry).
- **Setting**: where and when the story happens, and why it matters.
- **Plot**: five bullet points covering the beginning, rising action, climax, falling action and ending.
- **Characters**: for each main character, write one trait, one key action and one relationship.
- **Themes**: write each theme as a short sentence (for example, "greed destroys relationships") and note two scenes that show it.
- **Style**: narrator and point of view, language, tone, and figures of speech.

2. Learn the literary terms

Term	Meaning
Protagonist / antagonist	Main character / the one opposing the main character
Flashback	Scene set in the past
Foreshadowing	A hint of what will happen later
Soliloquy	A character speaking thoughts aloud alone on stage
Dramatic irony	The audience knows what a character does not
Stanza, refrain, rhyme scheme	Poem group of lines; repeated line; pattern of end rhymes

3. Answering objective questions

- Questions usually ask who said something, why an event happened, what a theme is, or what a figure of speech does. Match each question to your profile.
- Eliminate options that are true of the book but do not answer the question asked.
- For poetry, identify the speaker, the mood and the device before you read the options.

4. A weekly routine

- Read a few chapters or one act at a time, then write the five-line recap.

- Test yourself with the questions on ScholarAce and note every mistake in a notebook.
- Before the exam, re-read your profiles, not the whole book.

Note: Always read the actual set books yourself. Revision notes support your reading and cannot replace it.
